

Orientalism

In the late 18th and 19th centuries, a fascination with 'the Orient' developed in the West. Although Eastern architecture was little understood by Western architects, many of its decorative stylings were adopted as exotic elements. In the 17th century, Dutch traders had brought Chinese mother-of-pearl, lacquer, silks and porcelain to Europe, and this led to a fashion during the rococo period for chinoiserie (a decorative style featuring Chinese motifs) and to increased imports of Chinese porcelain. In his book *Upon the Gardens of Epicurus* (1658), Sir William Temple (1628–99) used the term 'sharawadgi', from the Japanese *shara'aji*, meaning 'symbolism in design', to describe a pleasing irregularity in landscape design or town planning. In 1757, Frederick the Great of Prussia (1712–86) had a 'Chinese teahouse' built in the grounds of his palace in Potsdam, featuring palm-tree-shaped columns, a curving roof and statues of Chinese figures (opposite). The publication of architectural pattern books, such as *Rural Architecture in the Chinese Taste* (1750–2) by William Halfpenny, fuelled the fashion further.

